

Vishal Kennedy

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SUMMARY

Environmental scientist with four years collecting, analyzing, and completing calculations on federal environmental datasets, and turning them into reports, dashboards, and regulatory documents. Trained in ISO 14001 environmental management systems and EMS audit methodology through an Exemplar Global certified Lead Auditor course, with a project management certificate underway at UT's Baker School. Award-winning federal policy writer on Clean Water Act implementation and watershed resilience, with applied work in clean energy and land-use regulation and EPA foundational training in the Clean Air Act and RCRA. **Available full-time on-site in Spartanburg, January 11 – May 14, 2027.**

CORE COMPETENCIES

ISO 14001 Environmental Management Systems · EMS Audit Methodology and Documentation · Nonconformity and Corrective Action · Continual Improvement (Plan-Do-Check-Act) · Environmental Compliance Reporting · Environmental Data Analysis and QA/QC · Digital Dashboards for Environmental Metrics · Advanced Excel · Regulatory and Permitting Documentation · Clean Water Act and Watershed Policy · Clean Energy and Land-Use Policy · Environmental Training Development · Biodiversity Project Design · Sustainability Project Support · GIS (ArcGIS, QGIS)

CERTIFICATIONS AND REGULATORY TRAINING

- **ISO 14001:2026 Lead Auditor Training Course** – Audit Workshop, Exemplar Global certified, *in progress*. EMS requirements, audit planning and execution, environmental aspects and impacts, nonconformity and corrective action, audit reporting, continual improvement.
- **Project Management Certificate** – Howard H. Baker Jr. School of Public Policy and Public Affairs, University of Tennessee, *in progress*.
- **U.S. EPA foundational regulatory training:** Clean Air Act and RCRA; with self-directed review of South Carolina DES permitting requirements.
- **Administrative and Regulatory Policy and BCPP 548 Public Policy Process** (Baker School, 2024–2025): rulemaking, compliance frameworks, agency enforcement.
- GIS Certification, Indian Institute of Remote Sensing (ISRO) · CIRTl Practitioner Certification · CITI Responsible Conduct of Research · Field Safety Training.

SELECTED POLICY AND REGULATORY WORK

- **Clean Water Act and Tribal Co-Management** – National Innovative Policy Memo Contest, National Wildlife Federation, **3rd place nationally**. Analyzed CWA implementation and proposed a modernized wetland protection framework.
- **Mississippi River Basin Watershed Resilience** – authored a federal policy memorandum for the National Wildlife Federation on conservation, flood resilience, and watershed management, synthesizing technical evidence into recommendations.
- **Clean Energy and Land-Use Regulation** – analyzed state and federal clean-energy policy with the Environmental Law Organization, including EV infrastructure, utility incentives, and clean energy standards, plus permitting, environmental impact assessment, and siting compliance.
- **Federal Comment Letter** – co-authored a formal comment letter to the U.S. Fish and Wildlife Service supporting expansion of the Okefenokee National Wildlife Refuge.

TECHNICAL SKILLS

- **Data and Reporting:** Advanced Microsoft Excel (VLOOKUP, pivot tables, multi-source data reconciliation), R, Python, STATA, SPSS, SAS.
- **Dashboards and Geospatial:** Tableau, Power BI, Google Analytics, ArcGIS, QGIS.
- **Documentation:** PowerPoint, Word, Outlook, SharePoint-style intranet and web content maintenance, LaTeX, version-controlled documentation in GitHub.
- **Methods:** environmental data QA/QC, auditable and reproducible workflows, policy impact assessment, cost-benefit analysis.

EDUCATION

The University of Tennessee

Knoxville, TN

Ph.D., Ecology and Environmental Policy · Focus: Environmental Management and Compliance Aug. 2022 – May 2027 (expected)

- Advisor: Dr. Paul Armsworth. 90+ graduate credit hours in environmental science, regulatory and energy policy, and quantitative methods.

RELEVANT EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Assistant (NSF-funded)

Knoxville, TN

University of Tennessee, Department of Ecology and Evolutionary Biology

Aug. 2022 – Present

- Collect, validate, and analyze federal environmental datasets (U.S. EPA ecoregions, PAD-US, USNVC) and complete recurring calculations feeding technical reports delivered on partner deadlines.
- Maintain documented, version-controlled analysis workflows so every reported figure traces to source data and withstands independent review, the same audit-trail discipline an environmental management system requires.
- **Develop and maintain data dashboards and reporting outputs** for environmental metrics, including summary tables, trend figures, and per-region breakdowns.
- **Design and implement biodiversity assessment projects** covering 210 vegetation groups and 270 vertebrate species nationally, in partnership with NatureServe.
- **Assess energy and land-use trade-offs**, evaluating renewable energy expansion against land conservation and biodiversity outcomes.
- Present findings in PowerPoint to technical and non-technical audiences and coordinate across university, agency, and nonprofit partners.

EcoLeaders Community Research Fellow

Remote

National Wildlife Federation

May 2025 – Oct. 2025

- Selected as a 2025 NWF Graduate Student EcoLeader Community Research Fellow.
- **Built and maintained digital dashboards** (Google Analytics, survey instrumentation) tracking program metrics, and used the data to redesign onboarding and program architecture, increasing engagement 283%.
- Authored the Mississippi River Basin federal policy memorandum and the award-winning Clean Water Act memo described above.
- **Coordinated community-based environmental outreach and education** earning the EcoLeaders Environmental Justice Badge, supporting the Okefenokee National Wildlife Refuge.

Campus Strategist and Training Program Lead

Knoxville, TN / Remote

Perplexity AI

Jan. 2025 – Oct. 2025

- **Coordinated and developed a training curriculum** delivered to 500+ researchers, staff, and faculty, and continually improved content based on feedback and usage data.
- Drafted responsible-use guidelines adopted at the departmental level and **maintained supporting intranet and web content** and internal communications.

Research Scientist

Manipal, India

Manipal Centre for Natural Sciences, Dr. Pandi Lab

Dec. 2021 – Aug. 2022

- Applied geospatial and statistical modeling to evaluate environmental performance against UN Sustainable Development Goals 13 and 15, and prepared technical reports translating the results into recommendations for government stakeholders.

Summer Down Under Research Intern (SDURI)

Perth, Australia

The University of Western Australia

Jun. 2021 – Aug. 2021

- Selected for a fully funded international research fellowship spanning agricultural policy and biology; collaborated across multidisciplinary teams and presented to stakeholders.

TRAINING, OUTREACH AND LEADERSHIP

- **Graduate Teaching Assistant**, UT Knoxville (2022–Present): instruct laboratory sections; CIRTL Practitioner certified in evidence-based instruction.
- **Darwin's Day, McClung Museum** (2022–2025): designed and led public environmental education sessions, exhibits, and visitor programming.
- **Youth Board Member**, U.S. Biosphere Network (2025–Present): authored a national ecosystem representation gap analysis and briefed agency audiences.
- **Appalachian Public Interest Environmental Law (APIEL) Conference** (2024–2026): attended three consecutive years, tracking developments in environmental regulation, permitting, and compliance.
- **General Secretary**, Student Affairs Council, IISER Kolkata: governed budgets and logistics for a 2,000+ member organization across multicultural teams.

AWARDS AND FELLOWSHIPS

- Tom Gilbert Award, Baker School of Public Policy · 3rd Place, National Innovative Policy Memo Contest (NWF) · EcoLeaders Fellowship (NWF) · A.J. and Evelyn Sharp and Breedlove Dennis Awards, UT · NSF Graduate Research Assistantship · SDURI Fellowship (fully funded), University of Western Australia.